Sequencers and narrating events

Goal: To put the events of a story in order using sequencers (first, then, next, after that, finally...) and to write a short, well-organised narrative in the past.

The idea in two lines: Sequencers are linking words that show the order of events in time. A good narrative has a beginning, a middle and an end, with sequencers guiding the reader from one event to the next.

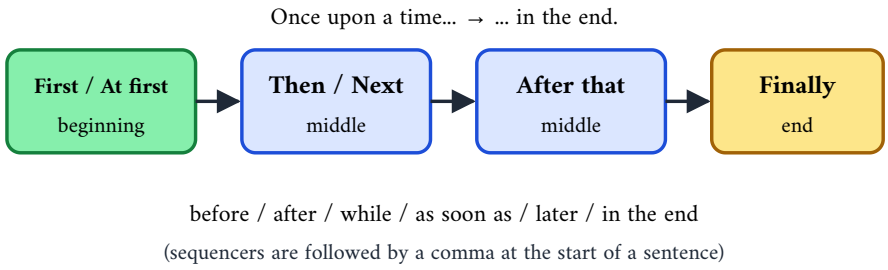


Figure 1: Sequencers lead the reader from the beginning to the end of a story.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Sequencers** show chronological order: first / at first, then, next, after that, later, afterwards, finally / in the end / at last.
2. **Position and punctuation:** most sequencers start the sentence and are followed by a comma: Then, we went home. "Then" can also follow the subject: We then went home.
3. **Time clauses** add precision: before, after, when, while, as soon as, until. After he finished, he left. As soon as she saw him, she smiled.
4. **Narrative tenses:** events are in the **past simple**; background and interrupted actions are in the past continuous.
5. **Story structure:** setting (who, where, when) → problem → actions → ending. Classic opening: "Once upon a time..."; classic ending: "...happily ever after."
6. **Variety:** do not repeat "then" in every sentence; alternate the sequencers.

🟢 Examples

1. Order the events: he arrived at school / he got up at 7 / he had breakfast. **Answer:** First, he got up at 7. Then he had breakfast. Finally, he arrived at school. **Explanation:** the logical order of a morning; one sequencer per event.
2. Join with "as soon as": The teacher came in. The pupils stood up. **Answer:** As soon as the teacher came in, the pupils stood up. **Explanation:** "as soon as" means immediately after; a comma separates the two clauses.
3. Complete: "... , the fisherman found a golden fish. ... , he put it back into the sea." **Answer:** One day / After that (or Then). **Explanation:** the story opening sets the time; the next sequencer links the second action.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Repeating "and then" in every sentence instead of using varied sequencers.
- Forgetting the comma after a sequencer at the beginning of a sentence.
- Mixing present and past tenses in the same story.
- Using "finally" in the middle of the story; it is kept for the last event.

🟡 Quick review

- First → then / next → after that → finally.
- Sequencer at the start + comma.
- Story = setting, problem, actions, ending; verbs in the past.
- Use before / after / while / as soon as to join events.
- Vary your sequencers; "finally" only once, at the end.

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